

Welcome Guide

Welcome and thank you for signing up. We're glad you're here.

Congratulation on prioritising your well-being. The first step is always the most difficult to take, and you have done that so you should be very proud.

We implemented the [mood slider](#), because research shows that if you can recognise how you are feeling on a day to day basis, you will be more able over time to recognise why you feel a certain way. The more consistently you record how you are feeling (at least every 2nd day), the more you'll start to notice what's making things feel lighter and better, and what isn't. Over time, that regular check-in becomes one of the best ways to learn more about yourself.

Before we start, how are you feeling right now?

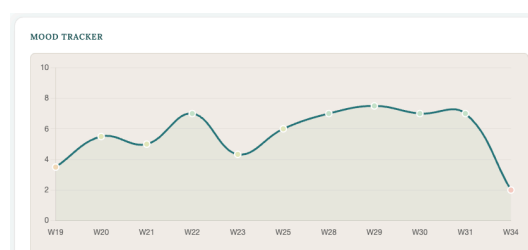
5
Getting by

I'm somewhere in the middle today — some moments are okay, others aren't. I'm not falling apart, but I'm not doing great either. I'll take it one thing at a time.

Really struggling Doing well

Check in and show me what's available

Also, check into your [dashboard](#) regularly, which shows you how you are tracking week by week. This will then provide you with the feedback you need to continue improving your well-being, continue doing the things that have worked in the past and also stop some of the more unhealthy or unhelpful things we do.



I'd also really encourage you to take the time to set your [personal preferences](#). The more accurately they reflect how you like to be supported, the more this tool can work the way you actually need it to.

What are you hoping to get out of this? Choose up to 3
This helps us point you toward the most relevant tools and resources from the start.

 Manage stress better Day to day pressures	 Lift my mood Feel more like myself
 Build better habits Small, consistent daily steps	 Strengthen my resilience Cope better when things get hard
 Sleep better Rest and recovery	 Ease anxiety Worry, tension, overthinking
 Stay connected Relationships, belonging	 Understand myself better Patterns, triggers, awareness

— CHECK-IN TIMING

What time would you like your daily check-in reminder?
Pick the time that works best for you on most days. You can change this at any time.

 5:00 pm   Brisbane 86° AEST (UTC+10) 

How often would you like us to check in?
You can always change this later.

 Every day Build the habit quickly	 Every 2 days A steady pace	 Every 3 days Light touch	 Not now I'll check in myself
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We are very excited to have our new resource search bar implemented on the website. You can type in things you would like to read or listen to and it will bring up the section with the most appropriate resources.

Not sure where to start? Tell us what's going on

e.g. I can't stop worrying about work

Find resources

Lastly, I want to continue writing new resources to assist you better. If you have a topic you were unable to find, offer some suggestions on how to improve this tool, please use the [Share Feedback](#) button to share your thoughts and ideas.

Lastly, I want to again congratulate you on your new journey.

Nic Marcon

Nic Marcon

Director/Principal Psychologist
Tools for the Tough Days

Where to Start

If you're not sure where to begin, you're in the right place. This guide is here to help you find the right support and start with the information that fits you best.

- **If you have a specific concern**, go straight to the matching section in “What’s in this guide.”
- **If you're feeling overwhelmed**, choose one section that feels most relevant and focus on just that today.
- **If you'd like extra support**, you can book a session with one of our Psychologists or Counsellors at any time.

If things feel unsafe or urgent right now

Lifeline is free and available on 13 11 14, Beyond Blue is available on 1300 22 4636, in an emergency call 000

What's in this guide

- Low mood and depression
- Anxiety and worry
- Self-esteem
- Anger and low frustration tolerance
- Burnout
- Sleep and sleep habits
- Relationships
- Grief and loss
- Alcohol, drugs and gambling
- Parenting young children
- Parenting teenagers
- Financial stress
- Life changes
- Identity and belonging
- Supporting someone else
- New parent and pregnancy
- Domestic violence and abuse

Take a moment to scan the list and start with the sections that feel most relevant to you right now. You can come back anytime, support can be built one step at a time.

Anxious or struggling with constant worry

What this can feel like

Your mind races ahead to worst-case scenarios. Your body might feel tight, jittery, or worn out for no clear reason. You might avoid things that used to feel great, or catch yourself checking and re-checking without ever feeling settled. Anxiety is a normal fight or flight response built to protect you, but when it runs constantly, it stops being useful and starts costing you sleep, energy and headspace.

What tends to help

Anxiety responds to small, repeated practice more than to one big fix. But most people will say that these things don't work, and that is because they have never done it before. You don't get good at something by doing it once. Practice makes perfect they say and I can tell you that over 20 years of helping people, it works if you do it regularly. Try and do these daily or multiple times per day:

- Practicing slowing your breathing
- Naming what you can control
- Reminding yourself what you cannot control
- Giving your body a couple of minutes to settle

All these and other tactics help retrain a nervous system that has gotten stuck in overdrive. Again, remember that doing this once will not shift much. Doing it most days, especially before anxiety tends to peak for you, is what actually changes things over time.

Try today: When worry or anxiety increases, go to a quiet place and take five slow breaths, in for four counts and out for six, before you do anything else. Remember that sometimes you have to do something more than once to actually start to feel a difference, so don't give up. Do it regularly or find something that does work for you.

Recommended resources are under "My Mental Health-Anxiety & worry"

- Understanding What Anxiety Is Actually Doing to Your Body
- When Worry Won't Switch Off
- Small Steps for Getting Through an Anxious Day
- Anxiety and Avoidance: Breaking the Cycle

Really down on yourself

Why am I feeling this way?

The voice in your head is harsher with you than it would ever be with someone else. Why? Because we all want to make sure that others like us, that we do the best job possible, have others like us and feeling valued. You might replay mistakes, assume the worst about yourself, or feel like you are never quite doing enough, no matter what you actually achieve. Low self-esteem often builds quietly over many years, so it can feel like that is just how you are, rather than something that has changed and can shift again.

What tends to help

Self-esteem tends to grow the same way it wears down, gradually, through repetition. Noticing when your self-talk turns harsh, and then deliberately doing these can really help:

- Asking yourself if you would say the same thing to someone you cared about. If not then you should challenge your self-talk
- Be honest if you have made a mistake, but then remind yourself that it is through mistakes that we learn and doing things repeatedly that will make you better at what you do

Good self-esteem takes time to develop, and regular practice will be far more effective than a one-off fix. You will feel awkward when you begin to challenge your self talk but that is normal, and it is part of growing and developing good self-esteem in your life.

Try today: Notice one moment of harsh self-talk today and rephrase it the way you'd speak to someone you cared about.

Recommended resources are under “My Mental Health-Self-esteem”

- Understanding Where Low Self-Esteem Comes From
- Talking to Yourself the Way You'd Talk to a Friend
- Building a Kinder Relationship With Yourself

Feeling flat, angry, or not like yourself

What this can feel like

Something feels off, but you cannot quite name it. You might be snapping at people you love, losing patience faster than usual, or just going through the motions without really being present. Anger in particular is often a signal that something underneath it, stress, hurt, exhaustion, needs attention.

What tends to help

Start by noticing the pattern rather than judging it. When does the flatness or the short fuse tend to show up, and what usually happens just before it? Once you can see the pattern, a short daily check-in with yourself, even a minute, helps you catch it earlier and respond to what is actually going on underneath, rather than reacting to the surface of it.

Try today: Before you react to something today, pause for a breath and name what you're actually feeling underneath it.

Burnout and running on empty

What this can feel like

You are not just tired, you are depleted in a way a weekend away does not fix. Things that used to feel manageable now feel like too much. You might feel cynical, disconnected, or like you are running on autopilot just to get through the day. Burnout builds slowly, which is exactly why it is easy to miss until it is serious.

What tends to help

Recovering from burnout is rarely about one big break. It is about consistently protecting small pockets of rest and recovery so your capacity can rebuild. That means actual breaks during the day, not only at the end of it, and being honest about what is unsustainable rather than pushing through it again. Daily protection of your energy, not an occasional reset, is what stops this becoming a cycle.

Try today: Take one proper 15 minute break today, away from your phone and your to-do list. Spend some quality time “just being” without doing anything. Find a nice spot outside, sit in the sun, take your shoes off, let your environment relax you.

Recommended resources are under “Work & Career-Burnout”

- What Is Burnout
- Recovering From Burnout
- Protecting Yourself From Burnout

Sleep, routine and the daily basics

What this can feel like

You know you should be doing the basics, sleeping properly, eating alright, moving a bit, but life gets in the way and it slips. Poor sleep and no routine do not just make you tired. They make everything else on this page harder to manage: mood, patience, focus, all of it.

What tends to help

This is the section that underpins nearly everything else here. The basics are not glamorous, but they are the biggest lever you have. A simple daily anchor routine, even just a consistent wake time, a short walk, and a wind-down before bed, does more for your mental health over months than almost anything else in this guide. Consistency matters more than intensity. A small routine kept daily will outperform an ambitious one kept for a week.

Try today: Pick one anchor, a wake time, a walk, or a wind-down, and commit to just that one thing every day this week.

Recommended resources are under “Health & Wellbeing-Daily habits & wellbeing”

- The Basics That Actually Make a Difference to Your Wellbeing
- Building a Daily Routine That Supports Your Mental Health
- Simple Habits for Better Sleep
- How to Rest Without Feeling Guilty About It

Your relationship is under pressure

What this can feel like

Conversations turn into arguments faster than they used to. You might be avoiding certain topics altogether, or feel like you and your partner are living parallel lives rather than a shared one. Trust, once knocked, can leave both people more guarded even when they both want to reconnect.

What tends to help

Relationships are maintained in small, regular moments, not grand gestures. A short, honest check in most days does more for a strained relationship than one big conversation every few months. If you are avoiding a conversation you know needs to happen, that avoidance usually costs more the longer it goes on.

The one thing that I believe every couple should be asking is “how do I make my partner’s life as positive as possible?” Now I hear you say, what about me? You are correct, it is also about your partner focusing on “making your life as positive as possible”. So if you both think like that then you can start the conversation about, what is one small thing we need from each other that can make our lives easier. It could be a 10 second kiss, it could be a meaningful hug after work, maybe helping around the house...

Try today: Ask your partner if what would one small thing that you can do make a difference in his/her life and visa versa.

Recommended resources are under “Health & Wellbeing-Daily habits & wellbeing”

- When Communication in Your Relationship Keeps Breaking Down
- How to Have the Conversations You Keep Avoiding
- Rebuilding Trust After Something Goes Wrong
- Navigating a Separation or Breaku

Going through grief or a devastating loss

What this can feel like

Grief does not move in a straight line, and it rarely looks like what people expect. Some days you might feel okay, other days it hits without warning. You might feel pressure, from yourself or from others, but the honest truth is that grief takes time. You can't ignore it, you can't always push it away. Sure you will have to work or do your daily things, where you can focus on something, but you also need time to heal from your grief. I hear a lot of people ask, "how long before I heal" I will generally ask "how long is a piece of string?"

What tends to help

There is no timetable to hold yourself to. What tends to help most is allowing grief the space it needs while still keeping a few small, steady anchors in your day, eating, moving, staying connected to at least one person, so you are not navigating it entirely alone or entirely unstructured.

Try today: Do one small, ordinary thing today, without guilt, alongside however you're grieving.

Recommended resources are under "Life Challenges–Grief & Loss"

- When Loss Hits and You Don't Know How to Keep Going
- The First Weeks After a Loss — What to Expect
- Grief That Doesn't Look Like Grief
- Supporting Yourself Through Grief When Life Keeps Moving

Drinking, drugs or gambling is becoming a problem

What this can feel like

I want you to firstly hear this: There is nothing to be ashamed of, we all struggle with addictions and our world today is filled with ads and social media bombarding us to eat this, buy this, play this. Addiction is a solution for a problem we are facing and are unable to resolve, it could be a feeling we are trying to achieve or avoid. For example you might have a drink alcohol to feel more at rest after work, you might find its the only way to “wind down”, it could be to stop the mind from racing at 100 miles an hour.

What started as something to take the edge off has started to feel less like a choice. You might notice you are doing it more than you intend to, hiding it, or feeling worse afterwards rather than better. Urges can feel sudden and hard to resist in the moment. You promise to yourself that you will not allow yourself to let the urges get the better of you “next time”, but then it happens again and again.

What tends to help

Change tends to come from small, practical steps repeated consistently rather than willpower alone: knowing your triggers, putting barriers between yourself and the urge, and having something specific to do the moment it hits. This is daily, ongoing work, especially early on, and it gets easier with consistency rather than intensity.

Try today: Name one trigger you can plan around before it shows up again, and decide now what you'll do instead.

Recommended resources are under “Life Challenges–Gambling & Substance Use”

- Staying on Track When Urges Hit
- Finding Your Feet After Gambling
- When Gambling Starts to Get Out of Control
- Cutting Back on Alcohol or Drugs

Things are tough with your young children

What this can feel like

You are doing your best and it still does not feel like enough. Your children show big emotions, and you do too. Things can escalate faster than you would like, and the guilt afterwards can be worse than the moment itself.

Raising children was never meant to be a one or two parent job. It was always the village that would help raise children. This we have lost in our current society, due to work commitments, financial pressures, social media ect.

What tends to help

The first thing I would suggest you do is to read the book by Gabor Mate and Gordon Neufeld "Hold On to Your Kids". They talk about the reason for kids no longer seeking adult connection and rather seek support and guidance from other children. This is obviously a recipe for disaster as we can all see with what is going on in our world. If you don't have time to read the book follow some simple suggestions they recommend in the book.

Reconnect with your children by doing things that they like to do or used to do. One-on-one time with them. They may push you away, but if you are persistent and tell them that you are taking them to the movies, or play some arcade games, take them camping, dinner ect eventually they will respond. Those activities are not about talking to them about what they are doing wrong, its just about spending time together. It is not about disciplining them to start with, you have been fighting that battle for a long time without any resolution. As children reconnect, they will start to come around and do the things that they need.

Kids respond to consistency more than perfection. They say that you should "Pick your battles" One of two small, repeated habits, a predictable routine, staying calm before responding rather than in the heat of it, protecting even ten minutes of your own energy each day, make a bigger difference over time than getting every moment right.

Try today: Ask your child what they would love to do, maybe its a movie, maybe its a game, camping ect whatever it is do it with them alone. If you have more than one child have each of them suggest something and pencil it in as soon as you can.

Recommended resources are under “Family & Parenting-Parenting young children”

- Caring for Yourself While Raising Kids
- Helping Children Manage Big Emotions
- Keeping Calm When Behaviour Escalates
- When You Feel Like You're Not Doing Enough

Struggling with your teenager

What this can feel like

You are doing your best and it still does not feel like enough. Your teenagers show big emotions, and you do too. Things can escalate faster than you would like, and the guilt afterwards can be worse than the moment itself.

Raising teenagers was never meant to be a one or two parent job. It was always the village that would help raise them. This we have lost in our current society, due to work commitments, financial pressures, social media ect.

What tends to help

The first thing I would suggest you do is to read the book by Gabor Mate and Gordon Neufeld "Hold On to Your Kids". They talk about the reason for kids and teenagers no longer seeking adult connection and rather seek support and guidance from other children. This is obviously a recipe for disaster as we can all see with what is going on in our world. If you don't have time to read the book follow some simple suggestions they recommend in the book.

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Staying connected to a teenager is less about big conversations and more about small, low-pressure moments of presence, being around, available and non-judgemental, even when they do not want to talk. Keep showing up daily in small ways rather than waiting for the big conversation that may not come on your schedule.

Try today: Spend five minutes near them today with no agenda and no questions attached. Maybe watch a show they like or watch them play a game.

Recommended resources are under “Family & Parenting-Parenting teenagers”

- Why Teenagers Do What They Do
- Staying Connected When Your Teenager Pushes You Away
- Helping Teens Manage Anxiety
- When You're Worried About Your Teenager's Mental Health

Money is stressing me out

What this can feel like

Money worries have a way of affecting every part of your life, e.g.: sleep, mood, relationships, motivation, and energy. It can feel like there is no way to think clearly about it because the stress itself gets in the way of thinking clearly about it.

What tends to help

Financial stress tends to ease with small, concrete actions rather than trying to solve everything at once. Knowing exactly where things stand by doing a budget on what you bring into the household and what you are spending on a weekly and monthly basis, should be the most important thing you prioritise. Then having one honest conversation with your partner (if you are with someone) or by yourself.

When you develop a budget, you will know exactly where the money is going, and you might say “well I already know” but having physical numbers talk to you will make all the difference. Then focus on where can you cut a few small things back, which can then go towards a bill you are overdue on. By sticking to a budget and following it regularly, you can slowly but surely make a difference and get on top of your finances.

Another thing is that by doing a budget you can then start telling your mind that you are working on a solution and by putting boundaries around how much time you spend worrying versus actually planning, you can start to get some stability back into your life. Remember it is one small step at a time.

Try today: Start writing one bill in your list, just one, rather than the whole budget at once. Do it regularly and before you know it you will have completed the full budget.

Recommended resources are under “Life Challenges–Financial Stress”

- When Money's Causing Stress
- When Financial Stress Starts Affecting Your Mental Health
- Practical Steps When Money Feels Out of Control
- Talking to Your Partner About Money Stress

Going through a big life change

What this can feel like

Whether it is retirement, a career change, losing a job, or everything shifting at once, big life changes can affect your sense of who you are, not just what you do day to day. It is common to feel lost, restless or unsure of your place, even when the change itself was expected or wanted. You need to be honest with your own feelings, and ensure you don't tell yourself "you should get over it" or "it's not as bad as someone else's problems". Your feelings are valid and true to you.

What tends to help

Rebuilding a sense of identity after a big change happens gradually, through small daily structure and purpose, not all at once. Give yourself a reason to get up, a small routine, a person to check in with, something to look forward to, while you focus on developing a strategy to manage your big change in your life. This is one of the areas where patience with yourself matters most.

Try today: Build one small routine into today, even if the bigger picture still feels unclear. It could be a new or existing hobby, some time going for a walk, exercising, meeting up with family and friends.

Recommended resources are under "Life Challenges-Big life changes"

- Retirement, Identity and Finding Your New Purpose
- When Life Changes and You Don't Know Who You Are Anymore
- Navigating a Career Change Without Losing Yourself
- Starting Over — What to Expect and How to Cope

I don't feel like I belong

What this can feel like

You might feel like an outsider even in familiar places, unsure where you fit or who you can really be yourself around. This can show up after a move, a change in circumstances, or simply build over time without a single clear cause. Getting to know yourself is something that our society does not often talk about, but you should get to know who you are, what you like, what you will not accept from others. Those that hurt you or diminish how you feel are obviously not looking out for you. Those people that say hurtful things should never be listened to, because those that make fun of others, or hurt others intentionally are often insecure themselves and need to work on who they are.

What tends to help

A sense of belonging tends to grow from small, repeated connection rather than one big change. Finding even one place or person where you can be yourself, and returning to it regularly, matters more than searching for a perfect fit all at once. Join a group or membership where you can be yourself and where you feel you belong. Ensure though that these relationships are positive, empowering and help you to achieve your life goals.

Try today: Reach out to the one person or place where you feel most like yourself. You don't have to chat about how you are feeling if you don't want to, but spending time with someone that gets you and accepts you for who you are can be a very powerful thing to do.

Recommended resources are under “Relationships-Identity and belonging”

- When You Feel Like an Outsider in Your Own Life
- Identity, Culture and Finding Where You Fit

I'm worried about someone else

What this can feel like

You have noticed a mate, a partner or a family member is not themselves, but you are not sure whether to say something, what to say, or whether it is your place. Staying quiet can feel safer in the moment, but it often means the other person carries it alone for longer.

What tends to help

You do not need the right words, you need to check in, genuinely and without an agenda, and keep checking in even if the first conversation does not go anywhere. Regular, low-key contact does more than one dramatic intervention.

Try today — Send the check-in message you've been putting off. Keep it simple, and don't wait for the perfect moment.

Recommended resources are under “Relationships–Supporting someone else”

- [Checking In Before It's Too Late](#)
- [Helpful Things to Say in Hard Moments](#)
- [What to Say When Someone Opens Up](#)
- [Standing Beside Someone When They're Struggling](#)